

34 Jethro

The priest of Midian who welcomed a fugitive, rejoiced in God's rescue, and gave Moses wise advice.

Jethro was a priest in the land of Midian and the father of seven daughters. When a young Egyptian-looking stranger defended his daughters at a well, Jethro invited him home, gave him his daughter Zipporah, and employed him as a shepherd for forty years. That stranger was Moses. Later, after the Exodus, Jethro brought Moses' wife and sons to the camp near Sinai. He listened to the story of Israel's rescue, praised the LORD, and offered sacrifices. The next day he saw Moses judging the people from morning to evening and gave him practical advice that shaped Israel's leadership. He was an outsider, yet he worshipped Israel's God and blessed Israel's leader.

At a glance

Name	Jethro, also called Reuel (Raguel in Numbers 10:29, KJV) (Exodus 2:18; 3:1)
Role	"The priest of Midian" (Exodus 2:16; 3:1; 18:1)
Family	Father of seven daughters, including Zipporah; father-in-law of Moses (Exodus 2:16, 21)
Descendants	Probably the Kenites, who lived among Israel (Judges 1:16; 4:11)
Key places	Midian, the mountain of God (Horeb or Sinai)
Main passages	Exodus 2:15–22; 3:1; 4:18; 18:1–27
New Testament	Not named

"Now I know that the LORD is greater than all gods: for in the thing wherein they dealt proudly he was above them."

Exodus 18:11, KJV

The life of Jethro

Dates are approximate (BC) and follow the early Exodus date, c. 1446 BC. On the late date, move them about 185 years later. Exodus 18 may be placed out of order: Deuteronomy 1:9–15 links the choosing of judges to the time Israel was about to leave Horeb.

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| c. 1486 BC
<i>Moses age 40</i> | ● Welcomes a stranger
His daughters come home early and say an Egyptian rescued them from the shepherds. Jethro asks why they left the man behind and invites him to eat bread.
<i>Exodus 2:15–20</i> |
| c. 1486 BC
<i>Soon after</i> | ● Gives his daughter
Moses agrees to live with him. Jethro gives him his daughter Zipporah as a wife, and she bears a son, Gershom. <i>Exodus 2:21–22</i> |
| c. 1486–1446 BC
<i>Forty years</i> | ● Employs Moses
Moses keeps Jethro's flock in the desert. It is while tending this flock that Moses sees the burning bush at Horeb. <i>Exodus 3:1; Acts 7:29–30</i> |
| c. 1446 BC
<i>Moses leaves</i> | ● Blesses his return
Moses asks to go back to his people in Egypt. Jethro answers, "Go in peace." <i>Exodus 4:18</i> |
| c. 1446 BC
<i>Near Sinai</i> | ● Visits the camp
Hearing all that God has done, he brings Zipporah and her two sons to Moses. He rejoices, praises the LORD, and offers sacrifices. <i>Exodus 18:1–12</i> |
| c. 1446 BC
<i>The next day</i> | ● Advises Moses and goes home
He sees Moses judging all day and suggests he appoint capable leaders under him. Moses agrees, and Jethro returns to his own land. <i>Exodus 18:13–27</i> |

Key activities

His names are debated. Reuel may be a family or clan name. Numbers 10:29 speaks of "Hobab, the son of Raguel," and Judges 4:11 calls Hobab Moses' father-in-law. Some think Hobab was Moses' brother-in-law.

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- 1 **Showed hospitality.** He scolded his daughters for leaving their rescuer at the well and brought Moses home to eat. *Exodus 2:20*
 - 2 **Took in a fugitive.** He gave Moses a home, a wife and work for forty years. *Exodus 2:21; 3:1*
 - 3 **Let Moses go in peace.** When Moses wanted to return to Egypt, Jethro did not hold him back. *Exodus 4:18*
 - 4 **Reunited a family.** He brought Zipporah, Gershom and Eliezer back to Moses. *Exodus 18:2-6*
 - 5 **Praised Israel's God.** He said, "Blessed be the LORD, who hath delivered you." *Exodus 18:9-11*
 - 6 **Worshipped with Israel.** He offered a burnt offering, and Aaron and the elders ate bread with him "before God." *Exodus 18:12*
 - 7 **Told Moses the hard truth.** "The thing that thou doest is not good." He urged Moses to teach the people and share the judging. *Exodus 18:17-23*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Jethro.

Old Testament

Exodus 2:15–22; 3:1; 4:18	He welcomes Moses and blesses his return to Egypt
Exodus 18:1–27	His visit, praise, sacrifice and advice
Numbers 10:29–32	Moses invites Hobab, "the son of Raguel," to come along
Deuteronomy 1:9–18	Moses recalls appointing leaders to share the load
Judges 1:16; 4:11; 1 Samuel 15:6	His descendants, the Kenites, live alongside Israel

New Testament

Acts 7:29	Moses "a stranger in the land of Madian"
Echo: Joshua 2:9–11; 1 Kings 10:9	Other outsiders praise Israel's God
Echo: Acts 6:1–4	The apostles appoint seven to share the work

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Jethro do when he heard what God had done for Israel (Exodus 18:9–12)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think Moses listened to advice from his father-in-law, a priest of Midian?
3. *Apply:* Jethro told Moses, "Thou wilt surely wear away." Where are you carrying too much alone, and what could you hand to others?
4. *Apply:* Who is a wise older person who could speak honestly into your life? When could you ask for their advice?